

Caesar learned his trade by following in his father's footsteps. His father showed him how to be a *praetor*, a senator and governor of an Asian province. Caesar learned how to talk to people. He learned how to think. He learned whom he could trust. His father made the introductions. His father set the pace. Then Caesar was able to step into his father's footsteps and keep on walking.

Caesar did not start from nowhere. He did not start with nothing. He started off where his father left him. He launched his career with the capital his father gave him: skills, reputation, experience, money, and contacts.

One of the many underrated legacies a parent can leave a child is a good reputation. Trust can take generations to build. We trust Mr. Martin to build guitars because his family has been making them for many, many years. We trust Mr. Ford knows how to make cars and Mr. Hershey knows how to make chocolate.

"The thing about doing business in China," said a man sitting next to us on an airplane, "is that it can take a very long time to build up trust. And without it, you're lost. They don't trust you. So they won't treat you very well. That's how they protect themselves, by cheating you first."

Trust reduces the cost of doing business. Less need for lawyers and contracts. No need for insurance, bonds, and hold-backs. That's one reason ethnic groups tend to prefer to do business internally. They understand one another. They know what to expect. They know whom they can trust . . . and how much.

Even in well-known, open careers such as filmmaking, banking and politics, trust, contacts, and "brand" awareness are extremely important. It's tough to break into acting or politics, for example, but it's a lot easier if your parents had already opened a breach in the wall. The number of people in the trade today whose parents and grandparents were also in it prove the point; there are far more of them than would be predicted by pure chance.

Of course, it's easy to see why. The children know how the business works; outsiders don't. They have the contacts; newcomers don't. People in the business trust them to know what to do and how to do it. So it's much easier to gain entry for someone such as Angelina Jolie (father: Jon Voigt), Michael Douglas (father: Kirk Douglas), Jeff Bridges (father: Lloyd Bridges), or dozens of well-known political figures.